of her husband and dealing with the clashing aims and murderous loyalties of the region's noblemen. Now, in 1595, with the fearsome dust of the Mughal army staining the horizon, the forty-five-year-old Chand Bibi worked hard to get the various factions in Ahmadnagar to unite against the might of the Mughal Padshah of Hindustan. For, as pointed out by historians Muzaffar Alam and Sanjay Subrahmanyam, the succession struggle that arose at this point was only the final act of a complex drama involving, among others, the strong Habshi (Ethiopian) element in the state, and the Mahdavi millenarial movement at the approach of the new Islamic millennium. Chand Bibi was finally allowed to assume the regency of Ahmadnagar, and an appeal for help was sent to Golconda and Bijapur.

But all was not well within the Mughal forces. Murad, as the twenty-five-year-old son of the Padshah, should have been in command of the army but Akbar, as was his habit, had appointed Abdur Rahim, the khankhanan, as joint commander. From all accounts of the time, Abdur Rahim and Murad did not enjoy a trusting relationship. It is highly likely that Abdur Rahim, ataliq to Salim, would have become implicated in the ruinous and covert battle for succession that had begun simmering at the Mughal court.* He would have been leery of wholeheartedly supporting Salim's biggest rival, his brother Murad, and thereby ensuring a spectacular victory for him in the Deccan. The Jesuits deemed Murad the most soldierly of Akbar's sons and, by all accounts, while Murad wished to act quickly and decisively, Abdur Rahim prevaricated, advising caution and patience. By the time Ahmadnagar Fort was besieged in December 1595, even the enemy had heard of rivalry in the Mughal ranks so that a spirited defence was mounted and the siege, sighed Abu'l Fazl, 'became a tedious affair'. Even more worryingly, the enemy appeared to have found a gallant champion for themselves who, 'in glittering armour, mounted on an elephant and, disregarding the barrage from the Mughal guns and archers' visibly moved among the troops, galvanizing them. Chand Bibi, it was agreed by all, had earned the title Chand Sultan.

Finally, with the possibility of a Golconda, Bijapur, and Ahmadnagar alliance looming, the Mughal forces laid mines at the walls of the fort of Ahmadnagar. Though the defenders were able to destroy most of the mines, the walls were breached nonetheless. The Mughals now prepared to storm the fort but Chand Sultan, 'clad in armour…with a drawn sword in her hand, dashed forward to defend the breach'. She remained in the breach all